A Catra Christmas Carol

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43734550.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

Character:
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Additional Tags:
Christmas, Drama, Angst with a Happy Ending, I'm Sorry Charles Dickens, Poor Life Choices, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Catra has parents

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Part 8 of In all kinds of universes

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A Catra Christmas Carol

by the_Frank

Summary

Catra D'riluth is cold, egoistic, mean and cares only about herself and her career.

But a late night meeting with an old acquaintance might change her mind.... and her ways...

Bah. Humbug.

Notes

A christmas Carol She-Ra style, and yeah. It's been done many times before.
AND will be done again!

So, let's not wait any longer, let us see who's who and what's what... one chapter a day until Christmas eve.

Additional carachters and tags will be added along the way. I do like my surprises...

A christmas gift to Mustlovefrogs.

Huge thanks to Bagge for endless support, comments and opinions.

CW: Mean people, immoral behaviour from young kids and drinking of alcohol, hence the Teen rating.

December 23rd.

A Catra Christmas Carol.

By the Frank

Somewhere far behind Charles Dickens and Nate Stevenson

Part 1. December the 23rd.

"...but as I have told you at least five times now, I don't care." Catra paused more to draw a breath rather than to listen to her girlfriend saying the same thing for the sixth time. "I am aware that it's Christmas, my love. If nothing else because you have emphasized on it for the better of this conversation. I am also aware that more than a few very important meetings are taking place tomorrow and… Yes, it's the 24th. So? …you are aware that Christmas is by definition a Christian holiday? …there are other religions in the world. …Business overseas is the most important thing for us." She pinched the bridge of her nose. The conversation with her mother had been tough but this one was way worse… if the women only could see reason! Catra was doing this for them! For their future.

"Look! I am doing this for us! I am this close… yes I am doing that finger thi-stop it! I am barely five meetings and two lunches away from becoming a senior partner in the firm. Then I can afford to get us that apartment. With room for the cats and the dog. And …what was that?" Her girlfriend's voice has sunken into a low mumble, but she now repeated it loud and clear.

"I said: if you keep being like this you don't have to bother getting that apartment. In fact, you don't have to bother calling me any more at all."

Catra went cold instantly. "...You don't mean that."

"Maybe I do, maybe I don't. Only one way to find out. Follow your heart, Catra. Let's see where it takes you. If you still have one."

"That. Was low."

"Was it? Remember how happy everyone was when Miss Weaver resigned? That she finally was gone? That luck didn't last long. You are becoming the next Sharon Weaver, Catra."

Catras' blood began to boil. "You take that back."

"It's true, Catra. I used to believe you when you said you hated her but now… You have become her, Catra. You never hated her, you admired her."

Catra had to bite the inside of her cheeks not to lash out on the phone. It took most of her willpower, but she managed to press out "I don't have time for this. I need to prepare for tomorrow. I will call you on the 25th and hopefully you have ceased with this nonsense."

"Yes, Miss Weaver. Have a nice day."

"NOW LISTEN HERE YOU C…"

But the line was dead. Catra threw her phone against the wall. It made a satisfying crash as it hit first the wall, then the floor. She then closed her eyes, counted to ten, and went to the bar. The bar had been restocked thos morning, and Catra made herself a rather hard Mojito. She needed something to take the edge out of her, and as she sipped on her drink she walked across the room, sank down in the couch and looked out at the skyline around her. Catra always booked a suite at the Elberon Plaza so when she had important meetings, or stuff to prepare, she wouldn’t have to commute. It was a nice suite, three rooms, bar, kitchen, jacuzzi in the bathroom… Lately however it effectively was her home. What had started as an irregular thing when she had to work over the odd weekend had turned into a more or less permanent solution.

And especially since Sharon Weaver had taken her as her protégé a few springs ago, the odd weekend had been at her old apartment in Arachnia District. The one where her girlfriend just had called her from.

Perhaps soon to be ex-girlfriend. The slight twang of bitterness was washed away by another swig from her drink.

Catra sighed. She wanted to be a big shot in the business and a big shot needed a wife. She had always seen the two of them standing together at the end of the rainbow, Catra being CEO of Horde Incorporated (or some other nice acronym), and her girlfriend-wife at her side.

"But maybe it's for the best." She said to the flat screen TV. "Maybe she wasn't the kind of wife material. She is pretty larger than life at times… She might be too hard for me to handle and I mean… Miss Weaver never married and…"

Another twang of bitterness. She was not turning into her. She was herself, she was Catra D'riluth! Daughter of Yana and Gomez D'riluth. And she was going to make her parents proud of her, dammit! And she had to stay on top, or else one of her primary competitors would grab HER rightful place. Especially she-who-must-not-be-named, her old nemesis. The one she had spent the better part of her life competing with. It had been tough and it was not over yet. But now she had fought for her place as "the shadow's" protégé and won, and Ad… The other one had to settle with Tim "Scurvy" Skinner… And he was an amateur compared with. …Alright, so maybe Sharon Weaver had been the huge b-ai-t-itch. But who cared, she got things done. Nothing wrong with that. She never played favorites, she said, but Catra took no chances. She knew her rival. She was tough and it took thick skin to be around her. But Catra could take the heat. Sharon Weaver never showed any human emotions.

"I wonder if the old hag even had it in her to actually like someone… Nah, she was probably married to her work."

Catra took another swig and remembered that no… Miss Weaver had actually been sapphic. Of course a twisted and cursed kind, but sapphic nevertheless. Catra recalled them standing in the office during pride and Miss Weaver had looked at the many rainbow flags, sneering and saying: "It is a shame and a pity that the only pure and sacred type of love is using such a childish and moronic symbol."

Rainbows… that got her to think. Catra walked over to check her phone. Huh. It was still working. Damn. She opened the message app until she found what she was looking for. The tenth text from Sophia inviting her to hers and her partners Christmas party. She had declined of course, already after the first one. That didn't stop Sophia. Sophia was Mr Hordaks personal driver and bodyguard and if you never saw her eyes, she was threatening and extremely intimidating, with arms wide as thighs… But if you talked to her? Waaay too friendly. She was easy to handle in small doses but a whole evening at a full blown hippie-yippe queer vegan Christmas party? No thanks. Not that Catra minded the separate parts! She was queer, full time lesbian. She was more or less vegan (it made her stomach less unruly, okay?) and she didn't mind the occasional yoga routine or some nice tarot readings.

Only not everything at once. And especially not with a side dish of Christmas.

(Not that Catra hated Christmas. This needs to be said: It’s legit to dislike a holiday, and of course the commercial aspects of it more than well shadows the more heartfelt and even religious aspects of it.

However, you should respect the people who really enjoy Christmas and want to share it with the world. Catra didn’t. In fact, she did something worse than hating it. She mocked it.)

Her phone rang. She put it on speaker.

"D'riluth. "

"*G-good evening, miss D'riluth. I am s-sorry to bother you, but there …there has….there has been A reschedule."*

The voice on the other side of the line belonged to Kyle, her oh so weak secretary. She drank her drink slowly as he spoke and replied coldly.

"What kind of effing reschedule?"

"The meeting with the Keldor Group, miss. They rescheduled tomorrow's meeting."

Catra sighed. The Keldor group was known to be impulsive, but rescheduling with only one day ahead? *Really?*

"Yes, I am sorry, miss D'riluth. But they said that the contract was more or less a formality so the meeting could simply be done after the new year. The preliminaries are signed and Mrs Lynn said that it was as good as done."

"I bet she did… lazy bum. Was that all?"

She had planned to focus on the meeting preparations to keep her mind from wandering to her mother and her girlfriend, and with that option gone, she planned to get as hammered as she could.

"Actually there's one more thing. Mr Hordak said that since this meeting was canceled, we could reschedule the meeting in the afternoon on the 24th as well, so you can get Christmas off. Both of you."

"And why would I want that?" No way she was canceling THAT meeting. It was her time to finally defeat her arch-enemy. She had been tough to crack but now… no way she was going to cancel that!

"Because I have recently lost a rather major asset, Miss D'riluth."
Catra sat up on the sofa. Mr Hordak! The man who owned the whole damn shebang! The one who decided.

"Mr Hordak! I…"

"As I said… even if Miss Weaver had her sides, she was a major asset. But in the end, she worked herself too hard. You have great potential, miss D'riluth. Both of you, but especially you. It would be a shame if you were to go down the same path."

Catra swallowed. On one side this would solve a lot. She would probably benefit some if she spent time with her girlfriend. However…. Mr Hordak was known for his 'informal tests'. This could just as well be one of those… And maybe if she accepted she wouldn't… and do the meeting by herself and win… Nope, not on Catras watch!

"Thank you for the offer, Mr Hordak." She had to clear her mind completely to keep her voice steady and clear. "But I assure you it's not a problem. I have everything prepared and I prefer to get the meeting done. After all", she added, "the Indian Market is a huge opportunity for us and it is a very dear thing to me to make it happen."

A few moments of silence.

"Very well. I have no doubt that you will succeed, miss D'riluth. But remember what I said. Losing Miss Weaver was tragic and I would hate to see you go the same way. Give me a short report after the meeting. Merry Christmas, miss D'riluth."

"Merry Christmas, Mr Hordak. Kyle? You're still there?"

"Y-yes miss."

"Send me the files for the *only* meeting on the 24th and go home. Damn man! You sound exhausted. Go home and get some d or something. Tomorrow at lunch I want you at 100%, is that clear?"

"...yes miss D'riluth."

"Good. Bye."

She sank down on the sofa, she had been standing up the whole time. And now she felt it in her legs. They were shivering. Damn it! She couldn't be that nervous, she shouldn't be. She went to the bar to refill her glass. A second mojito, slightly less strong. Even if she could spend some of the next day with a hang-over, she prefered if it was a light one.

She gave one final thought to Sharon Weaver. "Cheers, you old witch. Thanks for this time, but now it is my turn in the spotlight! Finally."

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Catra suddenly woke up, what time was it? And how many drinks did she have? Three? Four? She wasn't sure and since she had re-filled she couldn’t count the glasses…. Sometime last night apparently she had put the TV on, a b-movie was still playing. But the sound was low so whatever had woken her up wasn't the TV. It was an old cheap horror movie. Catta looked at it with a bored mind for a while. That makeup job was shit. But the light job was impressive. And when the killer stepped out of the shadow, Catra had to admit it was a cool effect. Finally she shrugged her shoulders. What was the time again? She looked at her watch, the rolex she bought when she landed the huge Spanish shipping contract. The other had settled for Portugal. Loser. Anyway, what did the bounty say the time was? 11.07 p.m. She hadn't slept for that very long then. Good, better to go to bed. The sofa was cozy, but falling asleep on it killed her neck. But 11 was early. If she'd actually gone to that party, she would still be there. Perhaps… She considered finding a movie she actually wanted to see on a streaming service but she dismissed the thought. Nah. Going to bed early was one of the few luxuries she allowed herself, save for watches and smart clothes. She turned off the tv, rose from the sofa, stretched her back, and left. The city lights gave the bright

moon night sky that weird effect where you couldn't see stars but it was still this weird kind of dark. The moon however, was out and made patterns with the windows on the floor. But a few corners the moonlight didn't reach, and there was nothing but darkness. Almost like in the movie where the killer had been… Catra froze. She had seen… no, she hadn’t. Hadn't there been something in that… in that corner? Something pretty tall… and dark… She lifted her phone to turn the flashlight on but lowered it again and threw it back on the sofa. She shook her head. Nope nope nope. She was not easily scared. There was nothing ominous with this room. Just a regular hotel room. Yeah.

"I am still buzzed." She went to the bathroom and drank two huge glasses of water. Then she undressed and went to bed. The moon shone in through the door, just a tiny streak, but enough to hit Catras eyes. It was enough to irritate her, even when she turned around, and she only saw the streak, it annoyed her. Finally she sat up, ready to close the curtains and the door.

She never left the bed.

The streak widened. The door to her bedroom made a veery small, but significant crack when opened at a certain grade. Yes, she wasn’t mistaken. The door was opening. Someone was trying to get into her bedroom!!!

No no *no.* It was just her imagination. The wind perhaps… or maybe just a bird passing the window, changing the shadow. Or the simplest solution, she still felt the alcohol! She was satisfied with her logical reasoning and prepared to calm down when she heard the steps. A figure came through the door. Slow and on unsteady legs, but forward and forward it strode.

Catra was never afraid. At least she would never admit it. She instantly took out the pepper spray from the bedside table, sat up and shouted "Don't come near me! Don’t come near I say! I will shoot!"

The figure stopped a few steps from her bed. In the darkness Catra couldn’t see anything other than tall. And then the figure spoke.

"Is that how you treat an old friend?"

For the fourth time that evening Catra froze in her place. But this time it was for real.

That cold, intense, ironic voice could belong to but one person in the world.

And that person had been dead since October and buried a fortnight ago.

"I noticed that you had helped yourself to quite the amount of alcohol. That is very unprofessional of you. If you want to get somewhere you can't be tar…OUCH." The figure seemed to have been punched over her ribs or something. It crunched a little, then continued moving inside the room.

Catra found herself taken over by complete and unhinged fear. She had no defense against this, even if it wasn't possible, this was Sharon Weaver. Dead. In her bedroom. Catra panicked and began to scream.

"You are dead! DEAD! I saw your corpse at the funeral! You can't be here! You can't… I won't let you take me! I won't! Go back where you're coming…from?" Catra had lit the bedside lamp and looked at the form in front of her. There was something off. Weaver was as tall as before, and she had the same voice. And she wore the same shade of red that she had preffered. But instead of a smart suit or a dress, this was a robe or rather a cloak. And there was no visible part of her face, only a mask.

"What the…"

The form nodded. "Yes. I am dead. And yet I am here. Your eyes are not deceiving you."

"What… What are you doing here? Why are you looking like that?

"My appearance we can discuss later. I have not much time. I am not allowed to tell you much about the afterlife, except this. Everyone, everything and creature that has lived gets judged. I was sent in front of the court. Weighed, measured… and deemed… unworthy."

"Unworthy? Of what?"

The ghost didn't seem to listen. Very Weaver, Catra smirked briefly to herself in spite of everything. She loved to monologue.

"I refused all of the things that matter in life. I was proud. I let greed and envy lead my way. And here I am. My punishment is simple, yet effective. I am to cease to be."

"What?"

"My mind, my memories and my voice will be lost in the darkness. My flesh and bones are to be melted down, back into the melting pot where we all come from. I will be one with the creation and… Hopefully, what once was me will be a part of a better creature or thing."

Catra bit her lip. It was so cheesy. Too dramatic. Weaver would never speak like this. So therefore…

"You… you are not lying."

"Oh, perhaps you want proof? After all, I did train you to only trust face value. Very well. See for yourself."

Sharon Weaver removed the mask. Catra gasped. The face had nuance of beige-grey, and her eyes were sunken in. But the worst part was the groped scar right over her face, dark green. And dripping… As she revealed her arms and legs, Catra saw. Flesh was dripping from her body. She was literally melting. Right in front of her eyes.

"Is…this what will happen to all of us?"

"Of course not. The better ones are allowed to keep existing. One way or the other."

Catra swallowed. "What about me then?"

"You? Oh Catra… You are like me. Unworthy. Unredeemable. Doomed."

Weaver put her mask back on.

"But I was given a small glimpse of mercy. There were a few years where I wasn't lost. And for that… I was allowed a short respite. A few weeks, to roam.the earth and say my goodbyes. I may not have many people left but there are places. I used to enjoy traveling. Long ago. Now where was I… oh yes. You. Catra D'riluth." The figure paused and pointed a melting finger at Catra.

"You won't even get that."

Catra bit her lip. The room felt like it was freezing.

"If my judge got their will, you would go straight into the melting pot."

Catra swallowed. The room was cold and yet she felt like she was sweating blood.

"One of my faults was to make others into me. And you… were my best one ever."

"I…what?"

"Yes, Catra. You were on your merry way to become like me. And as I was standing there… I felt… even if it was too late for me, you could still have a chance. You might be able to change your life. Maybe. I spoke for your cause. It was hard but they listened. You will be tried, on this very night, Catra."

"Say what now?" Weavers mask showed no emotion.

"You will be visited by three spirits. Listen to them. Follow their advice and maybe. Just… maybe….you won't end up like me." The figure turned around, ready to leave. Catra stretched her arm after her.

"Wait!" The figure turned.

"Yes? If you excuse me, my time is short and I want to see Paris once more."

"Paris?"

"The capital of France." Catra couldn’t help herself, she frowned.

"I know that! Why Paris?"

The figure looked away. "I was there once." A long pause. "With someone... very dear to me. That I lost."

"Oh."

"But you refuse to let me leave. Wery well, ask away. Be short, please do not waste our time."

Catra muttered something but managed to say out loud, "Why are you doing this for me?"

The figure was silent for a while. Finally she said "because…. I like you. I am proud of you. You remind me of myself, yes… but you have potential to… become so much more than that. And you can still change. Hopefully."

Catra was silent. The figure nodded and turned around to leave again.

"If you can, please remember me. Goodbye Catra. Listen to your heart. In the end, that's what counts. I never did. Oh, and one more thing."

Catra looked up.

"You're welcome."

And so the figure was gone.

Spirit of Christmas past

Chapter Summary

A flapping of wings... It’s time for a trip down memory lane!

Chapter Notes

Slight CW for immoral kids behaviour.

Again, thanks to Bagge for love, help and support.

Part 2. The spirit of Christmas past.

Catra woke up at the ringing of her cellphone. She looked around, confused. She was in her bed and it was still dark. Who the buck called *her* at night? What was the time anyway? And where was her phone? Ah well, it wasn’t important. She decided to ignore it. She let the phone go to voicemail and rolled over to her side. She wanted to go back to.sleep a.s.a.p. Whoever it was that called her could get ripped a new one in the morning anyway, no rush to do that now. Soon she was fast asleep.

Only to be awaken a second time by her phone. This time she ran out, searched through the sofa only to find her phone when it had gone to voicemail…again.

She went back to bed but sleep wouldn't come this time, there was something nagging her. Something vague….a dream… Ah yes. *Now* she remembered. She sighed. The dream about Weaver. Weird as snails on a boat. Ah well. She did have a bit too much to drink and this was probably the result. But what a result then… A nightmare about Weaver melting and something about a punishment and a meltdown… bah. Humbug. Now she was awake, AND annoyed. She knew the number, she would call back in the morning. And If she didn't catch the idiot that called her in the *middle of the night* she could always give Kyle a piece of her

mind for something. It didn't matter what, he was always a good punching bag. She was finally almost falling asleep again, wearing a smug smile over a very precious little smite that would hurt him *so* much, when the phone rang again. She groaned but let it go to voicemail. Then it rang again. And again. And again. This time, her ringtone changed, from her usual no-nonsense ringtone to some silly classical thing. That did it, Catra rushed out of bed and answered the phone.

"NOW LISTEN HERE YOU piece of absolute SHIT! What the heck do you mean with calling in the middle of the night! Honest people are trying to sleep you frickface! If I could get my hands on you…"

"I do NOT appreciate that tone from you, Ekaterina *!"*

The authority in the voice on the other side cut Catra off completely. For a second she imagined it to be her mother, since she was the only one to use her actual birth name occasionally, mostly when upset …which was most of the time. But this voice was different. It was….British or something. Far from Mama's Sochi accent.

"How do you… "

"No time for questions! We need to be quick. Are you dressed?"

Catra, who usually slept naked by habit gave herself a brief look and muttered "no…"

"You humans. Always the same. A well."

Catra heard what appeared to be snapping of fingers and soon she was dressed.

In shorts, clogs and a way to large t-shirt with a print of a whale.

"What the…"

"There. All done. Now let us go!"

"Go where?"

"You can start with going to the living room."

Catra muttered, but obeyed. *Let's play along,* she thought. *These people might be dangerous.*

Whatever she expected to see, it was not this. Weaver had looked like a classic ghost, but it might have been possible for it all to be a prank.

The window was opened, and gigantic angel came hovering in. She landed on the floor in front of Catra and gave her a disapproving look.

"I must say I hoped you would dress a lite more for the occasion, Ekaterina."

Flying alien or not, Catra was not to be scolded in her own quarters. She was an adult for freights sake.

"Well, someone who snapped their fingers clearly doesn't have any taste!"

"Do you treat your parents with the same disrespect, *young lady?* "

The angel gave her a hard disapproving look but Catra disapproved back.

"My mother and I argue as our basic communication, and my father is dead!"

"I see. Worse than I thought. Alright, let's get going. No time to waste." And with that, the angel grabbed Catras hand.

"What tiaaaaah!" Seconds later, they were up in the air. Brightmoon swished away beneath them, soon they had left the city and were far out in the outback. They didn't land until they reached a small town on the edge of the desert. There was a thin

layer of snow on the ground, which was quite unusual. Catra should know, she had grown up in a town like this. As she landed on the cold ground, she had imagined herself slowly freezing to death, but to her surprise she was still warm.

"This is a mental journey, Ekaterina. And there's no point in having you freeze to death too soon. I reckon you recognize this place?"

She was going to say no when she realized that she actually did. Crimson Junction. Her home for 19 years.

"Sure. The hole in the ground where I grew up."

"Are you always so rude?"

"Do you always walk with a carrot up your rear?"

The angel took a deep breath. "A simple yes had been enough. Anyway. Do you know when this is?"

"...The middle of the night?" The angel snorted her mouth.

"No. Come here." The angel touched a wall, making it glimmer and then led Catra through the wall of a house. There she saw two well-known characters. Of course! How could she not recognize the well known one store house. Her house. Once and there they were. Papa on the sofa, complaining over his back after a hard day of work. Mama making the table. The stoves and plates filled with food told Catra it was Christmas. The sight made her realize how hungry she was but she couldn't smell anything.

"Mama! And Papa! He's… alive?" She tried to run up to him and give him a hug but she just ran through him.

"This is just a vision of the past. We can't change anything. It's basically a recording."

"What the f…"

"Ekaterina!" The angel and her mother reacted at the same time. Catras father looked up.

"Ey, concita! What was that about? Catra isn’t home yet!"

Catras mother looked confused. "I do not know… It just felt like it was necessary. "

Catra didn’t want to show the angel how disappointed she was, instead she pointed at her mother. "See? See what I had to live with!"

"Yes yes. Please don’t interuppt."

Catra glared at the angel, and had a reply on her tongue. However, in the next moment, the door sprung open and schoolgirl Catra entered. Her clothes were dirty and her face was a mess, but it was apparent that the reason was "rough playing" and nothing else.

"Mama! Papa! You can't guess What Adora got for Christmas!" Yana looked her daughter over, sighed briefly and walked over to the dinnertable.

"No we can't and we won't. You are late!" Catra got cut off in her enthusiasm, but she wasn't going to give up yet.

"But mama! It’s Christmas!" Yana just looked at her.

"That may so be, Catra, but we still keep dinnertime! Go wash your hands." Young Catras' face soured. But she turned around and went to the bathroom.

"Yes mama…" She was back a minute later. "What’s for dinner?"

"The traditional Christmas dinner. Duck with Apples, pirogi, blinis and Pie."

Catra made a face. "Mama! Why are we always eating weird stuff?"

Yana gave her daughter a stern look.

"Так что не разговаривай со мной, юная девушка! You apologize. Now. Or you go to bed without dinner!"

Catra sterned back, but a growl from her stomach ended the battle. A day out with her friends had made her hungry. Not looking her mother in the eyes she finally squeezed out:

"...Sorry…"

"I did not hear you."

"Sorry mama."

"That is better. Listen. Even if I can not understand what it is you find appetizing with it, I will not stop you. You can have all the yankee food you want for the rest of the year. Oh, I know that Adora kid feeds you hamburgers! But once a year, we honor our heritage! "

"What about the other heritage? Papa is mexican! Why can’t we just have tamales?"

"When he learns to Cook tamales, we will honor his legacy! Now come and eat."

Young Catra sat down and glared at the table but after a while she resigned and began to stuff herself with pirogis.

Older Catra watched with a strange feeling in her stomach. When she noticed the angel looking at her she splayed her hands and said: "Look! This is what I had to put up with!"

"Always food on the table, clean clothes?"

"Patched up clothes! Heck, my pants used to last from when I was seven to 12! Mama just patched the hemlines to make them longer! Ad… My friends always got new clothes."

"But you still had clothes. And food." The angel didn't deadpan, but it was damn close. Catra wasn’t going to budge though.

"Weird food! Old clothes! Who cares about clothes and food?"

"I happen to know a few who would." The angel wasn't mad, only disappointed. Just like… Catra bit her lip. They watched in silence the little family dining. Catra reluctantly admitted to herself that… part of her missed her Mama's cooking. A small part, but anyway. However, halfway through the meal, young Catra couldn’t hold back.

"Mama? Can I tell you about Adoras Christmas present now?"

"Yes, if you must."

Young catras eyes glowed. "She got a BICYCLE." Her father looked up from his plate with a wrinkled forehead.

"Huh. I had no idea Radnor could afford that. I smell something fishy."

Catras' happy face faded. "Papa! A bicycle is awesome." She paused, then added "I want a bicycle."

"You have a bicycle!"

"Пиздец, papa! That's Abuelas' old rusty thing! That will fall apart as soon as I look at it!"

" *Ekaterina! Я не потерплю, чтобы вы втаптывали в грязь наш благородный язык! принести извинения!"*

Catra glared at her mama, but she glared back and it was obvious who the better glarer was. "Sorry mama."

"You are forgiven. I may let it slip some time, I admit it. But do not say those words again!"

"No mama."

"Anyway, that bicycle is good enough for you."

"But Adora's is brand new!"

"Every bicycle is brand new once, niñita, eventually it will be old. Besides, it still works, I looked it over yesterday. You can still use it without trouble for a few years." Her father, the bicycle repairman, spoke with the brief authority his occupation allowed him to have.

"Why can’t I have a Christmas present?" Her mother looked up and pointed at her with her fork.

"Because Father Frost doesn’t come until New Year's Eve, Ekaterina." Catra sighed dramatically.

"And let me guess… I get a small Toblerone."

" *Ekaterina!* If you are going to be nothing but ungrateful, you will be sent to bed without dessert!" Yana stood up, but so did Catra. Gomez was silent. Catra wasn’t.

"I don’t care! I hate you! I hate you both! I know papa earned good money this month! Adoras bike cost her dad only 25$! Why can’t I have one? Because you hate me, that's why!"

And with those words, without waiting for the scolding that would come, Catra ran outside. The scene froze for a second. Old catra knew where she would go. She would hide in an old well, until papa came to get her. She remembered this day. She sat there for an hour, angry. Angry at mama who was so unfair. Angry at Papa that didn't support her. Angry at Adora who got all her fancy stuff. But she would show them. She would show them all… especially Adora. She looked up to see the angel examining her. Trying not to give herself away, she yawned and turned to the angel. "Are we done? You see how it was for me! Absolute shit."

"Really now? Yes, maybe from where you stood. But, let's stay a little longer…" the scene began to play again.

" *Ekaterina! Come back!"* Her mother shoted at the closing door, the she sighed. Her husband said with a sad tone. "She has your sharp tongue." He paused. "And mama's temper."

"And her patience." Yana added. Pause. "She had so very little." Gomez nodded.

"Yeah." They sat in silence. There was plenty of food left but it was hard to eat now. Finally Yana spoke.

"Did you put the extra money in the college bin?"

"Of course. " Again silence. Yana had a sad look Catra couldn't remember she'd ever seen. She was usually just tired or angry.

"Gomez…возлюбленный… are we being too hard on her? She used to be such a sweet little angel and now…"

Gomez slowly walked over to his wife and embraced her. "The world had never been keen to angels. She will learn the worth of hard work. That is much more valuable."

Yana looked out the window, far away in the distance. "I hope you are right… Shall we have some tea?"

"Of course! And we must save some sweets for Catra."

"She has not deserved it." Now *that* was the mother she remembered.

"No, but it is Christmas." And *that* was papa…

"You are too kind, Gomez."

"And that is why you love me, mi muñeca."

"да"

The house and the people faded away. Catra and the angel was left.

"Well?"

Catra bit her lip harder. Soon she would break through. "...they weren't kind to *me* . But I learned the importance of having money."

Angella cleared her throat. "I admit they could have been less rough. But did you not once stop and think they had a reason for their behavior?"

Catra didn’t answer that.

"Can we please go now?"

"Not yet. A few more things before we go." Angella snapped her fingers and the scene changed to an old rusty playing ground. A teenage Catra sat on a swing, A teenage Adora sat on a broken merry go round. Lonnie Martinez, a girl their age, lay in the grass.

"So. We have in total 3 dollars and 73 cents. That’s enough for *one* slargesode *or* two small.” Adora counted on her fingers.

"If we sweet talk old Mr Sanchez he might give us three small?" Catra added, hopefully.

"No way!" Lonnie interjected. "That dude is a first class pervert. Octavia tried that. Showed him her tits and all that jazz. He looked at her for five minutes, then said that she tried to bribe him and he would call the sheriff if she tried that again!"

"What a a…Butt."

Lonnie sighed. "Catra, still not allowed to swear? You're so lame."

Catra shot up from the swing. "You take that back!" Lonnie gave Catra the raspberry. "Oh you little…" and then Catra attacked. The fight was short but brutal. It was more or less a draw, catra was lean but Lonnie was a brick house. They stood there panting for a while.

"Are you guys done?" Adora said, without any interest in the answer.

"Yeah."

"Yeah, we're good."

"Great. Let us focus on the important things then. We need money. We don't have money. We can't get money from home. We have to find work to get money."

"Laaame"

"Maybe so, but we could earn maybe… 10 bucks a week! That will give us the opportunity to actually get *three* sodas *and* a bowl of fries." Adora counted on her fingers. "Adam works at the grocery store. He gets 3$ a day. He has to give 2$ to mom but after a week, he can even have a Burger!"

"Alright. Fries are not lame, I give you that. And burgers are heaven…" Catra's eyes sparkled at the thought. Lonnie licked her lips and nodded.

"So, where do we find work then?" Adora looked at Catra.

"Your dad?"

"The bicycle repair shop? Sure, if you want to work for *peanuts!* But no. Papa doesn't have that much to do during winter."

"If we smash a few bikes…?" Catra shook her head.

"Uncle Sancho tried that last year to bring more business to papa. The sheriff got suspicious when 25 bikes had flat tires on the same street." Adora looked at Catra in shock. However, Lonnie sat deep in thought.

"I … may have something. Mrs Ramirez and mom talked the other day and I heard her mention that Mr Ramirez was looking for people to work at his warehouse. "

Catra clapped her hands.

"Perfect! Let's go!" Lonnie looked sceptical.

"I dunno. Mr Ramirez can be pretty mean. I think Adora should go. And me." Catra stared at her.

"Why you?"

"Dor is the all American girl. Mr Ramirez will hire her for sure and she can recommend me."

"And why not me?" Catra's eyes shot lightning.

"Face it, Catra. Ramirez hates Russians.

He thinks your mom is a commie. He will never hire you.

Catra got red in her face. Adora put her arm on her shoulder.

"Hey, it's okay! Between Lonnie and me, we can pay for your soda until you find your own job."

Catra muttered something.

"So, shall we go?" Adora looked expectantly at Lonnie.

"Nah, I need to go home first. Make sure none of my brothers need babysitting."

"I come with you. Catra?"

"Nah. Mom wants me to come home for dinner."

"Okay! See you later."

The scene faded. Catra looked more bothered now than before.

"As I said we don't have that much time. So I don't have the time to show you, because we have one more very important place to be. But you remember what happened after this?"

"...I ran home to dad….And he came with me to Mr Ramirez… They knew each other from the army…"

"And?"

"I Got the job…"

"Aaaand?"

"Managed to fix so that Adora and Lonnie didn't get one." Angella crossed her arms over her chest.

"That was quite rude, you know." Catra splayed her arms.

"Come on! I was the victim! Adora is the all American girl next door! She could find work anywhere! What options did I have? Besides, I bought them sodas that same saturday!"

"That was nice, but honestly Ekaterina. What options did *they* have? And how often did you buy them soda? Didn't you keep the money for yourself?"

Catra looked down at her clogs.

"...not all the time."

"But often enough. So, how long did it take for Lonnie to get a job?

"Hey, Lonnie got a job! At the gas station!"

"Yes. One year from now. And Adora? It was only luck that gave her the job at the stables. And how often did the three of you get sodas after that?

Catra was silent.

"I am not going to say anything. From the look on your face you have enough to think about."

"Can we please go now?" She didn't want to look the angel in the eyes.

"No. As I said, there is one more thing."

Again a finger snap. It was not exactly Christmas now, but it may have been a few days before winter break. A slightly older Adora ran up to Catra.

"Catra!"

"Adora."

"Where are you going?"

"Home. School is out."

"Yeah but…"

"But what?"

"Look, we haven't hung out in ages! I know we both work extra but… look, Mr Ramon gave us that test when we return. I was thinking… we could study for it together."

"I don't think that is a good idea, Adora"

"Why not? Catra, what's wrong?" Catra bit her lip. She had hoped Adora wouldn't ask her.

"Because Mr Ramon is on the scholarship board. I want to get away from here, I *need* to get away. Mama and papa don't make much money. But I want to go to college, Adora. I want to go to a university. I want a *life.* "

"Catra… we can still study? I want to go to college too!"

"No we can't. Mr Ramon hates me. "

"He doesn't…" Catra pointed at Adora.

"He accused me for cheating on the last test and gave you A+ for having good handwriting!" Catra laughed. "Coming to think about it, that's how it always is for you, isn't it, Adora? Everything you want just comes to you. But this one is *mine! I* will work *hard* all by *myself!* No one will ever doubt me again!"

"Catra! Okay, I got that good grade but… I worked hard for it too!"

"Yeah, tell yourself that, Adora! But I have seen you wink with those blue eyes and get extra candy in the shop. But now it's *my* turn!"

Adoras eyes flashed. "Oh, so that's what you think?"

Adora's eyes got cold and even bluer than usual. Catra had rarely seen Adora angry, and it honestly frightened her a bit. But she wasn't going to be intimidated by anyone anymore. Not even her nest friend. So she stared back. Adora was the friendly one, she always backed down.

"And here I thought we were friends."

Until today. But Catra wasn’t going to break habit.

"Yeah. Maybe you were wrong? Maybe you are wrong about lots of things!" Catra saw Adora clench her fists. Old Catra remembered how she in that moment wished that Adora would hit her so they could fight it out, like they always did… but she remembered crystal clear now, what had happened. And the scene in front of her just confirmed it.

"I will show you, Catra. I work hard to get what I want and luck has *nothing* to do with it. I will show you. I will show everyone!"

Catra stood eye to eye with Adora. One more inch and their noses would touch.

"Do your worst, Greyskull."

"I will, D'riluth ." Adora began to turn around, but stopped briefly. "Nice knowing you."

Young Catra waited until Adora was out of sight. Then she shed exactly two tears, bit her lip until in bled and went home.

Old catra almost did the same, but she had better defense mechanisms now. She knew how to get insulted.

"Can we *please* leave now? You saw it! She always had to prove she was better than me and I wouldn't Let her! We've ben competing ever since that! Okay, I get it! I should have accepted her being the great one and just stay in Crimson and been miserable while she saw the world!!! Is that the lesson?"

Catra had been waving her arms up and down and now she was panting. Once she had calmed down, the angels spoke with a soft voice.

"...Ironic, isn't it? You tried both so hard to push each other away and yet… who got that scholarship?"

A long pause.

"...both of us."

"And who got into business school?"

An even longer pause.

"Both of us…"

"I will let you draw your own conclusions from this, but I hope I gave you something to think about. *Now* we are leaving. You better prepare for the others."

"Others… oh yeah. You are the first of three spirits?"

"Yes. I was Angella, spirit of Christmas past."

" *Was* angella?"

"Christmas *past*, remember?

A short flight back and Catra was back in her room again. She felt dizzy and.lay down on the bed again. She sighed. If this was how every spirit would be, they could save it. And what a condescending spirit *this one* had been! Trying to get her to forgive Adora. Never! Catra hmpfd and pulled up the duvet.

Spirit of Christmas present.

Chapter Summary

> More flapping of wings with a slight hint of hooves... It’s time to show Catra what she misses this year!

Part 3. The spirit of Christmas presents.

Catra couldn’t sleep. She wasn’t going to admit, -she would *never* admit- that the first spirit had hit a nerve. No, by all the world's CEOs, she was never going to have trouble sleeping due to a bad conscience. So she blamed her unruly stomach. Imaginary or not, that flight had upset her internal system!

"Stupid wings… I hate flying. Aren’t spirits these superior higher beings that can choose whatever appearance they want or something? Why couldn’t I get the hoff and K.I.T.T or something? He sure is sanctimonious for two, but I mean… still, *the hoff!*"

Gradually she resigned, and lay on her bed, staring out in the dark room. It was an odd bedroom, the rest of the suite had grand windows giving an excellent view of the city. Why didn't her bedroom have windows? Oh yeah. It had. Two. But one was partly covered in a film with a clearly over-designed pattern, which she always hung her bathrobe over so she didn't have to look at it. In the darkness she gave it an evil glare. And why even put a window in a bathroom? And in a hotel? Okay, privacy was one thing but really… If you stayed at a hotel with someone, what was left to hide? Losers. Catra sure had nothing. There was a second window, but that faced the kitchen. None of those windows made sense. None of the city lights from the other windows leaked through anyway, and the door waa on the other wall.

"GAAAAH!" Catra exclaimed. Here she was, in the middle of the night, thinking about effing windows. She sighed and resigned.

There would be no sleep. She reached out for her phone and mentally slapped herself when she remembered that she had left it in the living room. Ah well. Maybe time was of no importance. If they could travel to Crimson Junction in a blink, they could probably run one minute in 59 seconds. Catra lay silent in the darkness doing her best not to think about windows for what felt like ages, and probably was, when she heard a commotion outside the door.

"Effing finally" She muttered. She left her bed and entered the living room. "Alright spirit. This better be go…ood."

In her room was a horse. A horse with wings and a horn, but still at the Core, a horse. Catra hated horses. She pinched the bridge of her nose and groaned.

"Alright, horse. Let's cut this short. Where's your owner? I don't have all night and I need to be reformed before morning, okay?"

The horse neighed and looked at her.

"Why do I bother… Alright Catra. We are professionals. We can wait. We will sit in that chair and have a drink, something with rum. Or even whiskey. I mean, it's not like the night could get any… HEY! STOP!"

The horse had begun to sniff and proceeded to move towards the kitchen part of the suit, straight towards the fruit basket. It was a really large and diverse fruit basket courtesy of the hotel, filled with hip fruit that Catra never bothered to try. The horse wasn't as picky and dived in on the cherimoyas, the pineapple, the caramboles, yes l even the cumquats! Catra tried to push him away, but it was a lost cause. And her attempt to pull his mane only ended in an annoyed look.

"What is this? What kind of a shit lesson is this? Do you want me to understand it's important to savior the earth by having a stupid horse waffle down hipster-oranges?"

"Excuse me! That's really rude, I am simply doing my job and I deserve to be treated with respect."

Catra facepalmed. "Of COURSE it’s a *talking* horse."

"Yup yup! The only walking, talking, flying, horse in the world. I am the spirit of all horses and I will never stop my fight to create horsely working conditions for my people! This for example! This is unacceptable and I will bring it up on the next meeting."

"…what?" Catra bit her lip, she didn't want to encourage the horse. She bit herself for making that mistake when the horse continued, even more agitated now.

"You think these are optimal work conditions? Haunting a greedy puny mortal at 1 a.m? The least I should receive is a reasonable compensation for at least five hours of uncomfortable work time, but no no no. 'Swift wind' they say. 'You are a being of light, one of the highest incarnations and for whom time and space means nothing. 'Stop talking like you're part of the working class!' They say! But they don't get that the fight is important! I act for ALL the world's horses! If I can get reasonable working hours, it will influence and improve the conditions for all horses round the world! For example, I wouldn't have had to eat from your fruit basket if I had time for a damn lunch break!" He paused. "Also, no apples? Really?"

Catra had an "I'm sorry" on her lips but she managed to hold it back.

"Look here! I don’t care about horse rights or horse shit! Do your job and get this over with! Feed me your moralizing for a few minutes and go have your darn break!"

"Lady, I want justice, not charity. I will do what's expected of me, because otherwise I would be playing their game and I want rights, not breadcrumbs! So, let's get going. We're going to do this the right way!"

Catta took a step forward, but stopped and pointed at the horse.

"What are you even going to do with me? You said you represent the horses! …don't tell me I was a horse in a past life." The horse neighed.

"Hah! You wish! Horses are noble and wise creatures! You are neighther of it! See what I did there? Huh? Huh?"

Catra groaned. "A socialist horse that tells dad jokes. Just kill me now."

"Be careful what you wish for. And if we are technical, I am not a horse. I am an alicorn."

"Alicorn."

"Yes, that's what I said."

"...What the frick is an alicorn." She bit herself again, but this time she was a bit curious.

"Wings *and* horn. To be precise, pegacorn, but I am also royal and wise, hence, alicorn. But enough about me. Now it’s time for YOU!"

"About bleeching time."

Swift wind gave her a flat look. "For being such a beeatch, you have very lame cuss words."

Catra shrugged her shoulders. "Mama raised me well."

"Partly at least!. Well then, let's go. Jump up!"

Catra waved her hands disapprovingly. "Uh uh! No no! No way! I have been flying enough for today!"

Swift wind looked insulted. "I'll have you know I take great pride in letting my passengers travel swift and safe!"

"I'll have *you* know, I take great pride in not throwing up!"

Swift wind still looked hurt, but in the end he neighed, shook his mane and pointed his horn to the wall. "Alright, be boring. This way then."

The wall disappeared and they stepped right into… another living room. The irony was not lost on Catra, but the sharp contrast in environment did soften that feeling. It was much smaller, because what room wasn't? It was also filled with way too many people than actually fit in it. They sat on the floor, leaned against the walls, sat/laythe sofa and the chairs and everyone seemed to have a genuinely good time. The room itself was one of those modern expensive boxes people dares to call flats. 'Gen Z bunkers', Weaver had once called them, and sure enough, there were the Christmas lights in odd places, the hip/ironic movie posters on the wall, way to.many candles that probably was scented and twenty varieties of the word LOVE in all colors and fonts. And yet there was something incredibly honest and wholesome about it. Whoever lived here believed in it and it was hard to deny that. Catra had never seen it irl, but she knew instantly where she was.This was Sophia's home.

And speak of old Mr nasty himself, the woman in question ran into the room, carrying bottles and plates in a dangerous was. And sure enough, she dropped at least two, but no one seemed to care, a broom.was brought out and the party continued. Sophia continued to run to and fro, refilling glasses, picking up dishes and generally making sure everyone was having fun. Catra sneered at her. She barely had time to sit down and talk before she was up and running again. Fool. And yet… Sophia seemed to genuinely enjoy herself, that much was obvious. Her partner Patricia was roaming the rooms as well, but in a much gentler pace. They enjoyed themselves as much as Sophie but at a more controlled pace. Giving everyone a smile and a bit of attention. Catra had read so many texts and emails about 'connecting' to people. It was all so false and a complete waste of time! And these imbeciles seemed to….actually appreciate it? How? With so many people there was so many things to do… Talking, drinking, eating, dancing (to horrible Christmas pop music), singing (even more horrible Christmas carols). Catra knew from earlier that while she

could see and hear everything, she couldn't smell. A few times times she was grateful for it, one time Sophia ran through her and the huge wet spot on her tank top…had to be nasty. But other times she caught herself longing for a sniff. Or even a taste, be it a lit spliff, freshly baked gingerbread cookies or a warm and moist mushroom and cranberry nut roast.

Alright. So, the food seemed to be good, very good even. She had to give Sophia that. Or Patricia, they were always the one in charge of dinner. The gingerbread was Sophia's though.

In a room with twenty-something people chatting or.just making noise, it was almost impossible to hear anyone who didn't scream, and up until now, she hadn't heard a word of what anyone said. But to Catras sudden surprise, she could hear the doorbell, Sophia's heavy breath as she said "I'll get it!", the door opening and a low voice saying "Hi Sophia. I hope I'm not late."

Catra didn’t want to look, but Swift Wind pushed her around until she couldn't avoid it. Her former friend and current competitor, Adora Greyskull.

Sophia gave the woman in question a bone crushing hug.

"You are just in time for the roast! Come in come in come in! Let me get you some punch! Oh, spiked, normal or 'far out'? No pressure, but I do think you should live a little!"

Adora smiled. "Spiked then. A small glass."

"Sure thing!" Sophia smiled and filled a very generous glass that she pushed into Adoras hands. Come here now! The second roast is done, you will love it I'm sure of it! I think you know most people iiiiin… that corner. Starla, Merinda, Doug the sea Hawk… oh whatever, you have time to talk to.them all! Sit down!"

Adora smiled, but a thought seemed to strike her suddenly.

"Isn't Catra here? I… I know you invited her."

A shadow passed over Sophia's face. "No… she said she was… busy."

"Oh."

Adora put the glass down then she looked at her phone for a few seconds, or did she just pretend to look? Catra wasn't sure. "I am sorry, Sophia but I just remembered that I have…something… to do. At home. It's a… I forgot to.prepare for a…meeting."

Sophia looked like she just seen a cat being thrown off a cliff. Patricia suddenly appeared behind Sophia, wearing a determined (albeit a bit stoned) face.

"Adora, I think you should stay. I would even say it's good for you to stay. This competition between you and Catra, it's not healthy. You look so pale. Do you get enough rest? Do you eat?"

"I do work out."

"Yes, Almost religiously and that is not bad buuut it can be too much as well. Come in here. Sit down. Relax. Let Catra be for tonight. It's Christmas."

"I… we don't…"

"Adora. Whatever Catra does, you do it five times harder? And for what? She doesn't care. "

For a second it looked like Adora was going to cry but she managed to steel herself.

"I… I have… I just really like my work, that's all! I have responsibilities! I can't just throw them away like that!"

"Adora." Patricia placed a hand on her arm. "If you really, really need to go, of course it's okay. We won't stop you, even if we care about you and we don't want you to hurt. But please at least consider it. What is one evening off? What can happen?"

"Yeah!" Sophia interjected. "What is it you need to check? That meeting with India? Adora, I know you. You probably know it forward and backwards. Give yourself one night off. Just one."

The three stood in silence in the middle of the constant noise for quite some time. Catra realized she had been holding her breath, when Patricia broke the silence.

"It's probably not good for Catra to work so hard either."

"How did bitchy mc Bitchface enter this conversation?"

A tall, buff lady with an appearance that screamed 'ex-marine' had walked up to the three of them. Catra instantly recognised her as Helen "the hunter" McGowan, the head of security…and even if it had been a few years… Catras ex. Patricia gave her a stern look that she didn't care about. She turned to Sophia. "Really now? You actually invited her? Stoneheart D'riluth? Why?"

"Helen, she's not THAT bad."

"No, she's worse."

Good to hear she's not bitter after the breakup, Catra thought to herself.

"Hey, no sarcasm at Christmas!" Swift Wind interjected.

"Can you read my mind?"

"No, you said it out loud."

"I did not! I was just thinking it!"

"Nu-uh. I heard you."

In the background, Helen was telling everyone who wanted to listen and everyone else what kind of person Catra was. She had heard most of it before so she didn't feel as if she missed anything. But… It was a strange feeling to know that someone

hated her so much. And to actually hear it? Catra knew that success brought you enemies but… to actually feel it? Helen wasn't done yet, but Sophia decided enough was enough. And Adora… Catra had always felt inferior to her but… was she working that hard? Really? She who always made it look…so… easy…

"...not to mention! That…"

"Helen, we appreciate your opinion, and we partly agree with you, but I think you need to focus on something more positive for now."

"Look, you were the one to bring up stuffed-arse-bitchy-face!"

"We… It was for Adoras sake, Helen."

"For Adoras sake? Oh come on! She would have a much better life if she just cut Catra off! Oooh by the way… Hi there… Adora…"

Helen had switched her tone to a more sultry one, Patricia noticed, but Sophia missed the cue.

"Yes, exactly that. We just want Adora to know that we want the best for her, Hele . "

"I wouldn't mind giving Adora my best. I am single, blondie. If you're interested, I would take you to the edge of the desert and back tonight…"

Helen gave Adora a meaning look as she took a big swig of her drink. Probably beer. Catra felt a reminiscence of how Helen was as a girlfriend and… she envied Adora. A bit. Patricia tsked and put their head on the side.

"Didn't you just kiss Dorothy, Helen?"

"Yeah. So?" Patricia still did their best to glare away the hungry look in Helens eyes, but when that didn't work, they took a step forward so they stood in between the hunter and her prey.

"Adora, what you need right now isn't some quick fix one night stand! You need…”

" Wanna see my biceps, blondie?" Sophia decided that enough was enough, and being one of the few large enough to look Helen in the eyes, she simply grabbed her by the arms and dragged her away

"Helen… you are drunk. Adora just arrived and she's sober. If you must hit on her, at least let her have an easy start."

"Buzzkill. Just because you have something sweet by your side…"

"*Bye*, Helen."

"Okay, okay…geez…"

Sophia sighed. "Sorry. She is really nice, I promise. But she gets… a little touchy when drunk. Now, let's go to the kitchen and get you some cake!"

Adora looked uncomfortable, but finally she followed Sophia and Patricia into the kitchen and soon they were gone behind the crowd. Catra looked after them but they didn't return.

"Can we go home now?"

"Had enough? Sorry, but no. You have to visit a minimum of two places. So now… " Swift wind poked the wall with his horn and again the wall disappeared.

Another room, one she knew well. Her and Glimmer's apartment. The only sound came from the TV. Glimmer sat on the sofa, with a glass of wine in front of her and a bag of nuts. Melog the cat and Bow the dog lay on her knee and feet, respectively. Glimmer had her sole attention on the movie. Terminator 2. There was nothing Christmassy at all around her. That was weird. Glimmer loved Christmas. But there was nothing. Not even a mistletoe. Glimmer suddenly let out a sob and glanced over at the small table next to the door. A medium sized package lay there. Catra looked at Swift

wind who nodded back. She walked over. "To Catra from Glimmer. XoXo."

Catras insides turned into a block of ice but she had no time to wallow. Swift wind spoke up.

"Wow. Forgot to buy your girlfriend a gift. That's a low if I've heard of one."

The guilt caused Catra to lash out, that damn horse had no right… "I didn't forget! I told Kyle to buy her… He! He forgot. …Moron."

Swift wind gave her an unimpressed glare. "Oh yeah. Having your assistant buying a gift. How romantic."

"Shut up! It's the thought that counts! Glimmer would appreciate it no m…"

"Merry Christmas, Catra." Catra swung round. Had Glimmer… She looked at her girlfriend, who was looking back at her, she gave swift wind a glance, but her looked bored. She looked back at Glimmer again. She took a deep breath. Not the best time to cry, just be honest.

"Glimmer, I am so sorry but…

"Merry Christmas, Glimmer" Glimmer said, in a voice that probably was meant to sound like Catras. "Wow, thank you so much for the gift. I love that designer. You are so attentive to details, Glimmer." Pause. "i just want to s-see you happy, C-Catra…"

"Glimmer! Please! Please don't cry! I love the present, I really do, I…" Catra cried, was there really no way make Glimmer hear her?

"Why! Why! Why did I have to fall in love with her? Why, Bow, why? Why, melog? Why?"

Bow lifted his head and panted. "But she was so cute… and fun… and charming. She absolutely swept me off my feet. Was it all for show? Didn't she mean a single thing she said?" She paused,

while Bow stroked his head reassuringly against her legs. Melog yawned and moved closer, they began to purr.

"Glimmer please! I love you, I do! I… I just… I just wanted to… take care of you…"

"Thanks guys… Yeah, I'm glad you're om my side, Melog."

Traitor, Catra thought to herself. The cat was hers. Melog seemed to look at her for a second, Catra bit her tongue.

Glimmer continued in her mock-Catra voice. 'I have to work late, Glimmer. This is a very important conference, Glimmer. If I do this I can pay the morgage of the house, Glimmer."

She took a deep swig of her wine. Glimmer was more of a whiner than a crier but now the tears came."Why couldn't she just see that I *didn't care*! Money never mattered! We had a *good* life! I didn't *need* perfect! I didn't need to be a fuxing princess in a fuxing *castle*."

"It mattered to me, Glimmer! I was going to show them! I was going to show them…all…" Catra was more or less screaming right into her ear now, desperate for Glimmer to hear her, to understand…

"A nice rack, great hair and a cute nose. Was that all I was for you, Catra? A figurehead on m/s Catra, ready to sail out in the sunset?"

Catra had sunk down at her girlfriend's feet, desperately trying to get her attention.

"No! No! Not… in the beginning…"

The only one who seemed to take notice of her was melog, who gave her a look. Sorry. You made this for yourself.

"I think I need some more wine, guys."

"Wooof."

"I know Bow. And I don’t care. Besides, she's probably drinking whiskey right now. I can have two glasses of wine. Or three. It's not like I will have company anyway…"

"Woof!"

"Miaow."

"You know what I mean." Glimmer went into the kitchen and returned with a refilled glass and some chips. As she sat down (and Bow and Melog regrouped tighter around her) she raised her glass to the ceiling. "Merry Christmas, Catra. I hope you get the worst hangover of your life and I hope you will cry for me then. And I am glad I won't hear it!"

Catra looked at Glimmer, arms hanging down. She stood there long enough for Arnie to blast through T-1000s skull and watch it reform.

"Can we go home now?"

"You don't want to visit your mum? It's a riot, she invites the neighbors over for some food and arguing?"

"...Please…No… please."

"Okay. Well, the rules say a minimum of two locations so I suppose it's approved. Just hold on, we're going home."

A final tap and they were back home. Again Catra was alone in her bed. Some final hoofsteps as Swift Wind finished the fruit basket, and then silence. In silence Catra wept.

Spirit of Christmas future...?

Chapter Summary

> The final spirit. Let us see what Catra have learned. IF she has learned something, of course.

Part 4. The spirit of Christmases to come.

Once the tears had ceased, she began to wonder what the next thing would be. Can you top an angel and a talking horse? And the message… It wasn’t like she didn't get it but… money wasn't bad, right? One could do so much with it! Was it really that bad? Was she really that bad?

At that moment the room was suddenly filled with light. The wall had turned into a gold light and a person came through it, walking towards her. It was a brown-skinned woman, but gigantic, almost as tall as the roof! Her brown, golden hair flowed like the wind, and on her head was a tiara. She was dressed fully in white, and she held a sword in her hand.

"I am She-Ra. Defender of the four realms, protector of the future and the guardian of Etheria."

"That’s a mouthful." Catra sighed internally. Could she say just one nice thing?

The woman smiled. "I know. Just call me Mara. Wanna go for a walk?"

Catra shrugged her shoulders. "Sure." They walked through the golden light and ended up on an endless field of grass. The air was light, it was morning. A beautiful day, it was promising to be. Catra felt calm

They could just walk for a while, in silence. It was… yeah, it was nice. Suddenly Mara stopped. Catra realised they were standing in the middle of a huge park.

"So… my future?" Mara smiled.

"What about it?"

"That's why you're here, right? You're all here to make me change my ways." Mara smiled.

"Maybe. I am very keen on free will, you know. I'm not going to force you to change."

"Not?"

Mara shrugged her shoulders. "No. You mortals have so many things going on. And you live such short lives. You deserve to at least exert your free will. And while we're on the subject… take a look over there!"

Two people sat on a couch in the shadow of an oak tree. Or, one sat on the couch. The other sat in a wheelchair.

"Who are they?"

"Go closer. They can't see you, remember?"

As Catra got closer, she recognised Sophia and Patricia. Patricia looked almost like she remembered, their long hair was grey, but they seemed as tall and slim as always. And they still had fresh flowers in their hair.

Sophia was a whole lot different. She was way much thinner, and her eyes and face were sunken in. Also, one of her arms was missing and replaced with some sort of metal arm. And it seemed like her left leg was the same.

They were sitting there in silence, just enjoying a nice day and each other's company. There was a bouquet of flowers in Sophia's

lap. Very beautiful summer flowers. Occasionally she glanced at the flowers with a sad look.

Catra turned to Mara. "What's wrong with her?"

"Cancer. Bone to be exact. She had to amputate an arm and a leg. But she got prosthetics." Catra stared at Sophia.

"But that's expensive! How could they afford that?"

Mara just smiled. Sophia opened her mouth. "Babe… I have to say… I am very grateful that Catra was persistent. "

"So am I, love."

"I mean, I didn't want to accept any alimony, especially not from someone that rich. But she didn't give up!"

"No…she didn't. "

"And thanks to her I am still alive today!"

"Yes. She deserves thanks."

Sophia got lost in thoughts for a while.

"It would have been nice to hang with her more… she was always so busy… But she gave me my legs! That's good!"

"I am so grateful to the stars that they let me keep you." Patricia's voice was thick with emotions and the old couple cried as they kissed.

Catra shook her head. "I…did that?"

"Well, it is a possibility at least. Always in movement the future is, you know."

Catra was silent. "I sure have given you something to think about, haven't I?" Mara smiled. "Oh, take a look over there!"

Suddenly they stood outside a huge building. "What does the sign say?"

"D'riluth Hospital?"

"Mhm. Oh, and look at that! Someone is going to hold a speech!"

A small group of journalists had gathered in front of a small podium. A large bald man was helping a very small, skinny man up to the microphone. Catra would recognise those eyes anywhere. Kyle!?

"I… can everyone hear me?"

The crowd nodded. So did Kyle.

"Good. I welcome you all to this opening ceremony for the D'riluth hospital. Well, the hospital has been open for a while, but it wasn't until today we could open the new section, the one for which… well, this whole building was raised. The Yana D'riluth-ward for COPD patients."

Catra began to cry. "Mama… I told her to quit smoking. I TOLD her"

Mara put a hand on her shoulder. "Well, at least you did a good thing to make sure no-one else would suffer like her."

Catra slowly nodded. She had tuned out Kyle now she tried to focus on him again.

"...and it is all thanks to Catra D'rulith, former CEO of Horde Inc. that we're standing here today. Her generous donation made this possible. We are all in debt to this wonderful and unselfish person. She worked 24/7 to make the world better. She really did! I was there with her!"

Catra stood mouth agape. Mara put her arm around Catras shoulder and led her away. "Let’s not let things go to your head. Perhaps we shall slow down for a bit?"

They walked for a while until they ended up at a cemetery.

"Interesting place to end at."

"Most things end here, but I…kinda like it here. It's calm and soothing. Oh! Take a look at that!" Mara pointed at a rather large monument.

Here lies

The earthly remains of

Catra D'riluth

Wife

Mother

Benefactor.

Patron.

Catra stood mouth wide open. "Pretty Impressive, right? This is the monument over you. Oh my. We seem to have company?"

Another old woman, supported by a cane and at least three grandkids approached the monument. She put down a bouquet of roses. "Merry Christmas, dearest wife. I suppose I will soon join you and finally we will be in the same bed at the same time."

"Not too soon, granny! You haven't teached me how to make your Sunday roast yet!"

"Yes yes… You kids, all you think about is food. very well. Let's go home."

Catra looked after them. "Was that… Glimmer?"

"Yes!"

"So….we did marry? She stayed with me?"

"You sure did! As you see, it's impressive how much money can buy you."

Catra was silent. "Is this my future?"

"If you want it to be."

Catra gave it a thought. Okay, so she apparently worked herself to death and never hung out with anyone. But she made everyone happy. And Glimmer did stay… And they must've had kids, right? Even if…

"How do I get it?"

"Easy." Suddenly the door to Catras' bedroom appeared in front of her. "Just go back inside, lay down, go to sleep. Tomorrow everything will be back to normal."

Catra looked at the door. Then at Mara. This hadn't been hard at all! So easy to follow her heart! Everything she was to do was great stuff! Weaver knew nothing!

..No, no. It was too easy. And she knew business, business was never easy. Something felt off. She hesitated. There were no other flowers on her grave. And the roses were not red, but white, with a few Asphodels stuck in.

"Just get inside." Mara was all sunshine and smiles, but there was something in her eyes now.

"I don't… I don't think this is me."

"Oh sure it is! This is definitely you."

Mara looked - and had so much - confidence in her voice. A bit too much. And what did she mean with definitely you? Catra looked around, and her eyes caught sight of another tombstone. Not as big as hers of course. But a lot of flowers surrounded it, and she recognised the bouquet that lay there. The one had been placed in Sophia's knee earlier. Catra had to know.

"Who's grave is that?"

"Ah, no one. Noone important."

"Sure is a lot of flowers."

"Indeed. So?"

"My grave has no flowers. Save for Glimmers."

Mara waved it off. "What is flowers? Nothing lastning, I assure you. And this doesn’t matter to us. It sure didn't matter to you at the end of it."

But Catra felt that just that person lying under that tombstone was very important. She took a step closer and kneeled down to see.

Adora Greyskull

2003 - 2054

We will always love and remember.

"Adora…"

"Yes yes. She died young. So sad. Now…"

"How did she die? She and I… we were both Weavers protégés. She was… my best friend."

"Good, you have the ability to remember a name. Still, you're not much of a best friend if you don't know where her grave is, is there now? Now…"

"She… I finally won. I took first place." She paused. "She didn't… I killed her. Didn't I?"

Mara was silent. "Didn't I?" Catra persisted.

Mara sighed. "Yes. Yes you did. She worked herself to death because of you. Because that's exactly what you do!" Her voice became harder and suddenly everything cracked. The surroundings rapidly changed. Gone was the grass and the cementatey and the blue sky. Instead they were standing on the edge of a gigantic….it looked a bit like a sea of liquid metal.

"This is the end, Catra D'rulith… This is all there is for you. You are shallow. Egoistic. Rude. Uncaring. You deserve nothing but to go straight into the melting pot!"

"But… but Weaver!"

"Yes yes, that old hag grew a spine after her death. She gave up a year for you to get this chance. But you had no chance to begin with, you destroyed it all by yourself !!! But what else was there to expect?"

"No! No! Mara, please…"

Mara began to cackle. "Silly mortal. I am not Mara… I am *Prime*."

Mara changed form into an imposing figure, like mr Hordak^10.. "I am Prime..the light of the world. I am the judge, the jury and the executor. Everything that lives come forward in my light! To be weighed and judged… unfortunately there are so very few I get to judge… most people have someone who cares for them. And if they have but one person who cares about them… the spirits always finds some kind of extenuating circumstances. But you… you have none. And now… You are mine!" Prime began to move towards her, inexorably and superior. She saw the end of her existence in his eyes.

No.

No it wasn't. It couldn't. If there was anything Catra could do, it was to fight.

"You are wrong. I don't care about that. I don't want my name on a hospital. I don’t want Sophia to think of me as a distant

benefactor! I don’t want Adora to die young!"

Slowly she rose. "I want my friends. I want my family. I want Glimmer. Even if I wasn’t standing next to a giant pot I would choose them over and over again. Because that is what I want. In my heart. I know that now."

Prime smirked.

"Why would that matter? This is all coming back to you, what you have done so far, the choices you have made… So many changes and you have thrown them all away. Look at you now. You have been given so much to think about, and yet… I only had to waggle all the things you can do with money in front of your eyes and you forget everything! All of that just to feed your ego."

Catra felt her tears flowing now. She was fighting for her life.

"No! I refuse! I can change!" Catra swallowed, but she was not ready to give up. "This is the *future* you said! A *potential* future, right? I can still change! I saw it! Mom still loves me! Glimmer cares!" She felt Primes mocking gaze at her, alright, maybe that was a bit too much to say. But… "Sophia… Sophia cares. And I never wanted… I don't want Adora to die because of me!"

Prime did not stop. Prime sneared, and kept walking towards her. Soon she would be pushed down in the pot. Catra tried to run, but she was stuck in the ground. Ah yes. Her legs had melted. She had nothing to walk with. It was all over now. One single tear ran down her chin.

Not sure you deserved it. But… I'm sorry I failed, "shadow" Weaver.

Then suddenly, there was a new flash of golden light. Prime turned his head, annoyed.

Again Mara came walking towards her, just like before. With her sword ready, she placed herself Between Catra and Prime. She was silent, but Catra knew. This was the real Mara.

"She is not done, Prime."

Prime hissed.

"I won't let you snag one more away from me, *She-ra*. This one has deserved no mercy "

"You know the rules, as well as I. And you said it, it's about the choices she made and will make. She is not done yet. She'll have plenty more choices ahead of her."

"A waste of time!" Prime shouted. "In the end, we will end up with another one in the pot! Just let me have her and get this over with!"

He took another step, but Mara held out her arm and he was frozen in place.

"Ekaterina D'rulith."

Catra was still sobbing. "Please… Please… I will change. I will make the good choices! I promise. If I only get one more chance… I will take it and honor it to the very end! Please!"

Mara gave her a soul-piercing look. Catra felt heavier than she had in ages. Behind her, she saw Prime managing to break out of the spell, and now he rushed towards her. Mara lifted her sword, but he was faster. And he gave Catra a push. She screamed until there was no more air in her lungs.

And then everything turned white.

December 24th, New years eve and a christmas a few years later...

Chapter Summary

Omg! Remember what happened in last chapter? I wonder what happened to Catra...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Part 5. December 24th, New Years eve, and a christmas way ahead in the future.

The white turned to gray turned to greyer turned to black. Catra didn’t dare to open her eyes. And yet… she didn't seem to be falling. And everything was quiet around her. But she wasn't ready to move. She wasn’t sure…

On the other hand, if she was being melted, that ought to feel a certain mealty way, wouldn't it? She slowly opened her eyes… and was greeted with a view of her feet halfway up the wall. She looked further down, and found her lowered back firmly placed against her pillow, with her neck and head against the mattress. The duvet had been tossed down on the floor. She blinked a few times. She rolled out of bed and ran out to the sofa. She instantly found her phone where she had left her it yesterday. The sun shone in from the large windows but she had to make sure… Time

was 10.15 a.m. and the date was… December 24th, 20xx. Catra sank down on the couch with a relieved sigh. She was back. Ho… not home! But alive, and…

Not done. Not yet. She rememebered most of the night. She wondered how much sleep she'd actually gotten. Not that much, but she still felt… rested. Fresh. Anew. She rang the reception.

"Elberon Hotel, this is Teela, good morning! How can I be of service?"

Catra didn’t feel the general sickness she usually felt when someone trained to be polite answered. Instead she smiled. It was nice to be greeted with a friendly voice.

"Good morning, Teela! As a matter of fact, you..."

Catra ordered coffee, milk on the side and three croissants. She had never been a big breakfaster, to her mothers dismay, and she usually skipped it. But, if she was to start anew, it began with being a good daughter and a good daughter eats breakfast. Even if it is a semi-traditional French one.

Two cups of coffee and 1.5 croissant made her feel incredibly good. Why hadn't she tried this before? From now on, this would be her life! Now she was more than ready to deal with the day!

And the first thing on her agenda was to mess with Kyle. She smirked as she found his number and pressed call. He answered after five signals.

"Miss D'riluth! I wasn't… i-I didn't… I'm sorry it took so long!"

"No excuses Kyle!" she replied, maybe a tad more sharp than usual. No matter, Kyle didn't notice.

"No miss."

"You need to step up your game. This tardiness won't take you anywhere."

"N-no miss…."

"Not to mention, how am I supposed to get any work done when you do something like this?"

"I'm…so sorry miss D'riluth. " Catra had to hold back a laugh. One last stunt on Kyle... Besides, he wouldn't belive her if she didn't rough him up a bit. She thought. (She was right, but it was a bit rude to assume it.)

"You better be. I have two things for you to arrange today. First thing is the most important. I need you to make an advert. I need a new secretary. "

"WHAT? I mean… of course… miss D'riluth. "

Catra smirked.

"I knew I could trust you. You know what characteristics I'm looking for in a secretary. In fact, that's the reason I need a new secretary."

There was a Pause. Catra could completely picture Kyles face, wrapped in confusion. It was getting harder and harder to hold back a full belching laugh.

"I…am not sure I follow, miss."

She smiled warmly. Time for the twist nobody saw coming!

"I could use something more. Not just someone handling my schedule or my papers. Someone I can share my visions with. An personal assistant. A right hand helper."

"I…see. You want me to type an advert for that as well?"

"No, that won't be necessary. I already have the perfect candidate. How long do you think it will take for you to show a replacement the ropes?"

"...Three weeks?" Kyle's voice was sad but there was a hint of interest...

"Perfect! Then you will start as my assistant in n + 3 weeks. We will look through candidates after 12th night"

Another pause. This time Catra did snicker.

"...Miss D'riluth?"

"You have something this business need. The human side, Kyle. I tend to forget that. You never do. That's why I want you by my side on a higher level."

"...geez… um…thank you! Thank you so much! But what will Mr Hordak say?"

Catra leaned back on her cushions and made her voice the most choose-free in the world.

"Ah! Thank you for reminding me! We will reschedule the meeting on the 24th, which is today, yes. But it's a holiday, let's be a little wild! Let's take Christmas off. Both of us. All three of us. I am pretty sure Mr Hordak won't mind."

Another voice butter in. Catra didn’t flinch.

"I assure you, I do not miss D'riluth. Good choice. Both for assistant and the meeting."

Catra smiled. She had suspected that Mr Hordak would listen in again. She finished the call, took a shower, got dressed and called a cab. Yesterday she had two difficult calls to make. Today she had a few difficult conversations to make. But in the cab she felt a new kind of calm. It was a beautiful day, at least as beautiful as downtown Brightmoon got. All the Christmas lights and tacky

decorations in people's apartments and offices gave everything a certain… light feeling. The salvation army on the corner probably did "away in a manger" without any soul but a great feeling. Catra smiled. As she passed the people in queue for the shelter, she saw a few people dressed as santa handing out sandwiches. Well, when one part of society falls, the other needs to step up. She made a mental note to put a fat donation to all the town shelters. An old man wearing a ragged army uniform slowly moved down the street. He looked so thin… but on his head he sported a pair of reindeer horns and in the pockets a few presents were sticking out. Catra smiled again. The cab ride took about an 25 minutes The subway would have been quicker, and cheaper. But she had one thing to do before she arrived. A bit of a warm up for the even tougher conversations… And even with her newly found concience, she wasn't stupid. She knew that people wouldn't accept her with open arms.

The cab let her out outside a huge apartment complex. She paid but waited for a moment on the pavement. She noticed the all night cafe a few houses down and went inside, ordering a latte. She produced her phone and typed the number. She didn't have to type the while out, she had it saved. As Stupid Horse Hair. She had to change that. She pressed call. One signal..two. three…..at six she answered.

"...mmdora Greyskull…"

"Hey Adora."

"Catra? …ra? What the… What do you want? If you have rescheduled the meeting I will…" the tired voice on the other side instantly got sharp and edgy. Catra swallowed, but she had to press on.

"As a matter of fact, I did."

"WHAT? Catra! This is l…"

Catra interrupted her, of course she would be mad but she had to listen.

"Listen! Adora! Listen to me! I rescheduled til *January*. It's not that important and we both deserve Christmas off, don't you think?"

"...what?"

Catra let out a relieved sigh. That was a voice she remembered. Ordinary, not-angry, slightly confused Adora. Catra was still slightly nervous and her old mock-voice came on.

"Is that all you can say? Really Adora! We both went to university!"

Was that to far? To early? Too… but the reply calmed her down again. Good old Adora.

"Yes, but… Aaargh! Catra!"

Catra smirked.

"Okay, Adora. Since you apparently can't speak anymore, I will do it for you."

Alright. This is the serious part of the pitch. No jokes. Be earnest. For once… "I will just say it as it is. I have been a bitch to you. Making your life awful for so many years, plain and simple. I don't expect you to trust me, or forgive me. I haven't deserved that. But… I don't want to be your enemy anymore. That meeting… "

She approaches the goals, rounds the defence… It's almost open buuuut…

"Yeeees…?"

"Let's do it together. Let's be partners. In business only! Because I won't leave Sparkles if I can avoid it."

Another pause, but not as long.

"...I need to think this through."

Aaand she scores! Adora would never just say yes, even if she was an idiot, she wasn't that kind of idiot. The most important thing was that she didn't say no.

"...is it okay if I call Kyle to double check? It's not that I don't want to trust you, but…"

"Of course. And I get it. Trust must be earned. It's okay. Do that. "

"Catra?"

"I'm here, Adora."

"...Ok, I'm not gonna pretend it will be easy as pie, but I'm not gonna lie. I have *missed my best friend. Heck, I kept fighting you because that seemed to be the* only *way to keep you being around me…"*

Catra felt something thick in her throat. *Oh Adora…* loud she said: "...you sly devil…"

"Learned from the best." Pause and muffled sounds. *"Okay, I must go now. But… coffee on the 2nd ...no 4th of January? A new start, trying to talk things through? "*

"Of course. But I... plan to go to Sophias Christmas Eve party. If you're going... we can see each other there."

*"Oh! Oh... um... I wasn't planning but... *mumbling* "I'll come! Sure, w...I'll come! ...It will be quite a lot of people so... Not sure how much talking we can do..."* Catras smile was wide with relief and pure joy.

"Patricia will be head over heals if I come. They will arrange a quiet nook for us, they've been dying for us to talk for ages."

"...Yeah... They have."

There was a silence. The elephant had wandered in from stage left. Sure, Catra was the big jerk, but Adora hadn't actually tried to talk to her either...

"Water under the bridge, fresh starts, we both have behaved stupid?"

"...Yeah. Fresh starts."

" Merry christmas Adora."

"Merry christmas ca…"

"Hey Blondie! Get your ass back in bed! Who are you talking to?"

The following silence was *so* filled with hidden meaning... *Oh Adora… you're such an idiot.* It was with a slight embarrassment in her voice Adora continued.

"...just an old friend…"

Catra smirked. "So you got lucky at the party last night, hmm? Good for you. And Huntara is a sweetheart under that bomber jacket. Keep her, she's a nugget."

"Wait a minute, how did you know…"

"Later, Adora!"

"Catra! Catra, wai"

But she had hung up, and Catra trusted Huntara to keep Adora occupied and not call back. Alright, that went well. Now for level 2. She walked back to the first building, entered the code, went inside and rang the doorbell. Nothing happened. She waited a few minutes, then she rang again. Again nothing. Her heart sank to her feet. She was too late. Ah well. 2 out of 3 was not bad and she knew she couldn't expect 100% perfection. Not after this…

She shrugged her shoulders and tried to soldier through her disappointment when she met her neighbor, madame Razz coming up the stairs.

"Well hello dearie!"

"Hello Madam Razz. You look well."

"Ah but dearie! You saw me yesterday!"

"Sorry, but that wasn't me."

"Don’t be silly, C'yra! I never forget a face! But I must hurry! I need to… oh what was it again… I ask Glimmer!"

Catra shook her head.

"No use. She's not at home."

"Nonsense! She helped me shop just this morning! AH! Yes! Now I remember! She bought some cleaning powder and asked if I needed some! And now I do, Looki that rascal has made a mess in the living room!" Looki was Madame Razz's cat that she always spoke about but no-one ever had seen. Catra shook her head.

"Well, she's not at home now."

"Nonsense!" And with a final uttering of her catchphrase, Madame Razz began to knock on the door, hard enough to make sure the whole house would hear her.

After merely five knocks Glimmer opened.

"Hi Razz! Already need that cleaning powder?"

"Oh yes, dear. That rascal cat was at my Petunias again! I wish he could learn that I don’t have any petunias, but he's crazy after all. Thank you dearie!"

Glimmer smiled and began to shut the door when Catra stepped forward.

"Glimmer!"

Glimmer stopped. "Catra?"

"Can I…come in?" Glimmer replied, more with surprise in her voice than anything else.

"Well, it's your apartment. Do as you want." Catra just murmured.

"Cool. Thanks."

She went inside, and closed the door.

"Is… the doorbell.broken?" Glimmer closed her eyes for a second.

"Yes. I told you two weeks ago but I can see that you don't remember. So, get to the point. What do you need? Shampoo? Clean underwear?"

"I want to…take you on a date."

Catra had no plan for this, she realized. Her original plan had left her mind once Razz had banged the door and she was not good at improvising kindness. Glimmers face was a picture of surprise, and there was even a hint of a smile. But that moment was soon lost.

"If you think it's enough for you to just show up for a few hours then leave you're wrong."

Catra shook her head. "I know. And I'm not. I… have cleared my schedule."

"Really?" Glimmer looked skeptical.

"Really. I'm actually… free over Christmas. Got the whole holiday off."

Glimmer took a step back. Tears started to well up in her eyes. "Don’t make jokes like that. It's not funny!"

"I'm not joking!"

Tears were welling up in Catras eyes as well and a slight desperation had entered her voice. Glimmers voice was taking right from a hallmark movie.

"Catra D'riluth, the *definition* of work-a-holic and careerist doesn't take Christmas off."

Tears ran down both their faces now.

"I did! I swear! Please! I can… I can call Kyle if you don't believe me."

Glimmer looked at Catra from hair to toe and up again. "Darn… You are serious!"

"Is that so hard to believe?"

"After the argument we had yesterday? After two years of neglectance? *Yeah!*"

Catra blushed and sat down. She tried her best to calm down. "Alright… Look. I don't expect things to change overnight. I have been the worst girlfriend. I know. But… I want to change. I can change, I want to change. If you give me the chance…"

Glimmer said nothing. She just grabbed Catras' collar and dragged her into a kiss. Once she let go and they both had caught their breath she said: "I'm not going to sleep with you at this moment if you think that! You're on a trial run, miss D'riluth. "

Catra smiled. God, was Glimmer beautiful… "I know. I said date and I meant date. Sophia has the second Christmas party tonight. I was thinking… Wanna come?"

The light in Glimmers eyes was enough. That girl LOVED parties.

*

Let us pull the curtain over the Christmas celebration at Sophia's place. Let's just say there was even far out music, far out food, pot and more than a few who woke up in a different bed than they went to sleep in than last night (Save for Catra. Glimmer wasn't jealous, she just preferred to have Catra for herself. And Adora. Apparently Huntara played for keeps.)

It was the most fun Catra had had in years. She also received the biggest of hugs from Sophia. She wasn't sure if it was a reward or part of her punishment.

But the toughest part remained.

*

Christmas day. The train ride had been long and exhausting. 5 hours, three changes and no open cafés since Albuquerque west.

"Why did your mom decide to live here?"

"Dad grew up here, it was cheap to live here."

"Okay, okay, wise guy. Why did she *choose to stay*? You have sent her money, haven't you? Haven't you?"

"Yes I have! Geez… Act like a jerk for ten years and no one takes what you say at face value… ouch!" Glimmer hit hard, and gave Catra a glare.

"Too soon?"

"*You think?*"

"Okay okay… I'm sorry. Anyway, she stayed because it reminds her of home."

"Which part? The village, nature and the awful communications?"

"Yes."

Glimmer glanced at Catra. "Unfortunately, I don't think you're joking."

There was a seven minute walk from the station to the familiar house where Yana D'riluth lived, alone for 5 years. Accidentally, it had also been five years since Catra began to double focus on her career. "Probably not a coincidence" she muttered to herself. "I need a therapist."

The house looked as old as she remembered, but there was sign of someone with green fingers trying to keep up some appearance, even in winter. They walked up to the door and rang the bell. They heard russian curse words long before the door opened and the small woman with even longer, although greyer, hair than Catra opened the door and looked out.

"I have told you so many times! I do not! Vant! Vacuum cleaner! I do not. Vant…."

"Привет мама. С Рождеством."

The older woman gaped with one hand in front of her mouth.

"Должно быть, я упал и ударился головой! Someone who is looking like my дочь and her girlfriend is standing on my porch. On Christmas day. No no no, this is not happening! You are pulling my knee!"

She did not try to close the door.

"Leg, мама."

"Who cares? Leg, knee, it's all below the влагалище! Now get inside! I am very mad at you, дочь! Treating your old poor мама like this! How long has it been since your last visit?"

Catra had a protest ready, but she placed a hand on her mother's shoulder and said "way too long." And then she started to cry.

"котенок, please do not cry! Because… then I will cry… as well!!"

Glimmer had no real reason for it, but she began to cry as well. She just loved these kind of movies. The three women went inside and spent echristmas day crying, arguing, crying a bit more and laughing more than Catra could remember her doing in ages. They stayed a week (although they moved into a nearby motel after the first night. Catras old bed was to small for two (yes, even someone as short as Glimmer) and they really really wanted to share beds again.) and Catra showed Glimmer all of her old hometown (that only took one day) and the rest of the time they spent… being together. Just being a couple. Catra liked that. Being with Glimmer was larger than life. Just as she wanted it.

Finally it was new years eve. After being completely stuffed, Catra and Glimmer sat on Yanas sofa and watched a turned off TV. Yana was out arguing with her neighbors.

"It's a tradition for mama. She's always done that on new years eve."

"Why?"

"She wants every disagreement to stay with the old year."

"Does it work?"

"You have met my mother, what do you think?" Glimmer nodded.

"Hey Catra?"

"Yeah?"

"Why are we really here now? I mean… I get that you want to show me and your mom your trying to change…"

"I have changed!"

"...Trying to change. You are on your way and you are making progress but don't push it."

"Fair enough." Catra muttered.

"But I… We could have gone home on the 26th, or came here yesterday I mean… If you wanted to celebrate Christmas or new years eve, but… both?" Catra looked away for a second.

"Yeah… I know. But I have my reasons. You see… In Russia, and in our house… Santa didn't come on Christmas eve."

"Umhm?"

"No, Ded Moroz, or Father Frost came on new year's eve to give presents. Usually candy, but from time to time papa would get me a real present 'just like a real American kid!' " She paused. "It didn't happen often, you know mama. But when he sat his mind to it, he was adamant on that one…" Catra cleared her throat. "SO! Anyway, I wanted this year… Father Frost to give you something really special. "

Catra produced a box from her pockets. "For you. From Father Frost and me."

Glimmer had her ideas what the box contained, but she wasn't sure. Until she opened it to reveal… a ring.

"Glimmer Moon. I know I have been an asshole. A huge asshole. And I know I'm not allowed to Curse and I know mama is hiding behind the door frame just to scold me when I'm done but I don't care. Let's face it… I have been an asshole. But I want to change. I want to change… for you. And if you want to stand by my side while I change… I would be the happiest woman ever. Glimmer… will you marry me?"

In that moment, Yana ran in.

"Say yes! Say yes! Or else I will spank both of you!"

*

Mid day Christmas eve a few years later...

"Tiana, sit still!"

"But mama! It’s boring! Why can’t we stay with Adora more? She's way more fun!"

Glimmer turned around in the front seat and said "First of all, of course it’s boring! That's why we do this trip by car so we will appreciate grandmamas food even more. Second, Adora needs to rest until next year when there will be three wild animals running around their flat. " Tiana started to pout, but in the end her belly won.

"Mmkay. Grandmamas food… it rocks." Glimmer smiled and patted her pregnant belly.

"That’s the spirit! Hopefully we can both be satisfied, fetus! Now let's rock some horrible Christmas songs."

Catra put her hand on Glimmers before she could reach the radio.

"Just a second…"

"What? Need to put in earplugs?" catra rolled her eyes.

"Nooo! I just… I just wanted to enjoy the moment. A few years back… I was so close to miss all of this. You, mama… Tiana… my new position…"

Catra smiled, Glimmer smiled back. Tiana did a 'yuck'-face.

"That allows you to actually spend time with your first and second Child… When ever she decides to pop out! Don’t mind that your mother gets a bad spine." Catra smiled wider.

"I'm just… grateful, that's all. I got a second chance. "

"Yeah… what was that Tiana?"

"What? I didn’t say anything!?"

Glimmer looked at her daughter, they both looked surprised. But then she shrugged her shoulders and proceeded to turned on the radio.

Seconds later, both Glimmer and Tiana howled along to José Feliciano and Feliz navidad. Loud, proud and out of tune.

But Catra gave her daughter a sideways look. Because Tiana had said something. Very low and in a voice not really hers. But she did say it.

"You're welcome."

Yeah.. Thanks a lot, you old hag. Thanks a lot.

Fin.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that's a wrap!
Thank you all for reading, I hope you enjoyed.
Merry Christmas 2022 and forward!

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